

Great Indian hornbill

Buceros bicornis

This large hornbill relies on forest fruit for food and essential moisture. Fruiting trees attract scores of birds whose droppings, in turn, help disperse seeds throughout the forest. The function of the angular casque is uncertain, but the larger bones in the bill have networks of hollow cavities, combining lightness with strength.

► LIGHT AND SHADE

Horizontal bands create effective camouflage in the light and shade of a forest canopy.

- ↔ 38–47 in (95–120 cm)
- ⚖ 7 lb (3 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🍌 Figs, lizards, frogs, rodents
- 🏠  S. and SE. Asia



Indian cobra

Naja naja

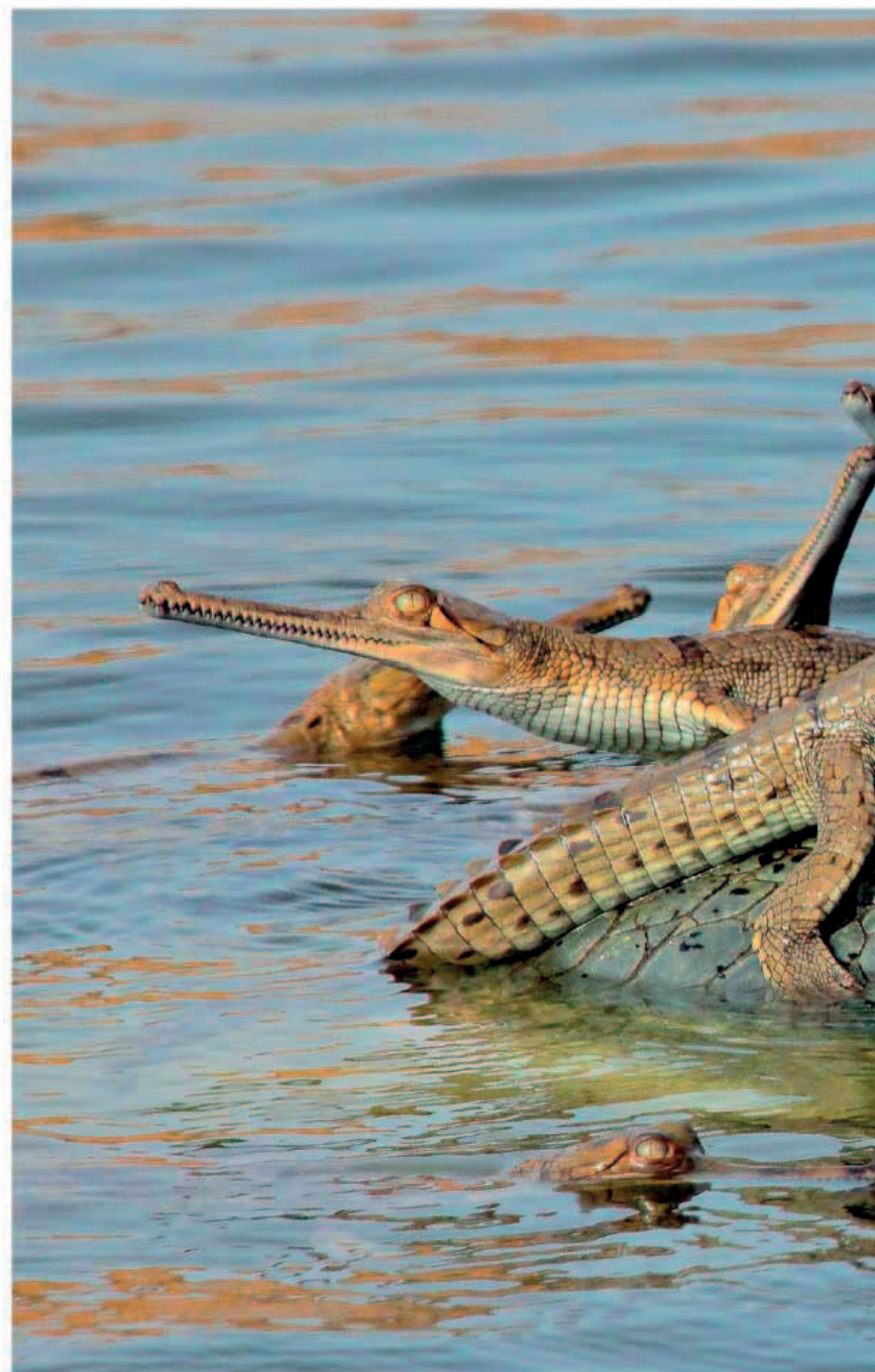
Found in habitats from remote uplands to urban sprawl, the Indian cobra's diet ranges from tiny frogs to large rats. Females lay 12–20 eggs in a tree hollow, rodent burrow, or termite mound, and guard them. Hatchlings can immediately spread their hood and strike with venom.



- ↔ 6–7 ft (1.8–2.2 m)
- ⚖ 5–7 lb (2–3 kg)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🍌 Frogs, rats, lizards, birds
- 🏠  S. Asia

◁ SPECTACLED HOOD

This classic “snake charmer” species is also called the spectacled cobra from the markings on the rear of the hood and often on the front as well.



△ SAFETY ISLAND

Parents care for the young for the first few weeks, escorting them on their first swims. However, many other crocodilians nurture their offspring for longer periods.

► FISH TRAP

The gharial's 100–110 teeth are small and sharp—ideal for snagging fish, which are bitten several times to subdue them, then tossed around to be swallowed head first.

